



Muslim graveyard. After much persuasion, the burial took place but the entire family was ex-communicated. A dejected Aziz finally migrated to a city in southern India to escape his daily dose of humiliation and ostracisation.

Nearly 24,000 men and women, mostly young, have attempted suicide in the last 17 years in Kashmir. Of them about 3,000 have been successful. Shockingly, most of them were between the age group of 16 and 25. The figures point to a psychological catastrophe in the conflict-ridden Kashmir valley. Three to four people

are admitted to SMHS Hospital on a daily basis, the main health centre in Srinagar. Rising suicidal tendencies amongst people is a matter of grave concern in the Valley where people have been witnessing conflict and violence from point blank range. "There was an advanced study of suicidal behaviour in India in 1980's where it was found that the rate of suicide was lowest in Jammu and Kashmir. Now the situation is entirely different," says Dr Arshad Hussain, a consultant at the Department of Psychiatry in Government Medical College, Srinagar.

According to the study in 1980, the suicide rate was 0.1-0.2 per 1,00,000 per year. It has now risen to 20 per 1,00,000, almost twice the national average of 11 per one lakh. The statistics of the World Health Organization

have also turned more brutal. Hussain, who has extensively studied the pattern of suicides in Kashmir, says, "Nowadays people are adopting more violent means to end their lives. For instance, several people slit their throats in the last few years—something that wasn't common earlier."

Records of suicide attempts and actual suicides in Kashmir reveal that the epidemic has gripped every stratum of society, from villages to cities. According to the SMHS register alone, nearly 13,000 people have attempted suicide between 1989 and 2004. According to the hospital records, more than 100 people were admitted to the hospital after attempting suicide in the month of May, while on the first three days of June itself, 15 cases were registered. This is the statistics for one hospital alone. Given the stigma Muslim societies attach to suicide, under-re-

20 per lakh is the suicide rate in

Kashmir, which is twice the national average.

(WHO) for 2005 reveals that the rate of suicides amongst Muslims is 0.1 to 0.2 per 1,00,000. An average of 3.5 attempts of self-annihilation on a daily basis in the last three years has made suicide the second most dreaded thing, after violence, in the Valley. While it is estimated that nearly 70,000 lives have been lost in the state since militancy erupted in 1989, attempted suicides during this period has run into thousands. In 2004, 1,137 people tried to take their own lives, 62 died. In the first five months of this year, 42 people committed suicide in the state. Not just have suicide attempt rates in Kashmir gone up a hundred times over the last decade, the ways of attempting suicide

porting is very likely, and the actual numbers could be much higher. The police records also amply demonstrate the unwillingness of people to register suicide cases. Compared to 716 suicide cases recorded with the police during the last six years for the twin regions of Kashmir and Ladakh, hospital records of SMHS alone revealed 1,137 cases for 2004. "We don't deny a larger responsibility towards social issues like suicides," says a police officer, adding, "the situation here is such that it is not a priority for us."

Shockingly, the trend has spread its tentacles to the armed forces operating in this strategic region. The police in the last six years have recorded 39 cases of suicide attempts among troopers with 20 actual deaths. Kashmir, traditionally a land of Sufis and saints, has been alien to instances of suicide among its inhabitants and that's best reflected perhaps by the absence of an appropriate word for suicide in the Kashmiri language. An adaptation has been borrowed from the Persian language—"khud-kushi" or self-killing.

Apart from the more obvious and tangible losses, the political turmoil over the last 17 years has had very serious but less discernable psychological effects on the people of the Valley. Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF), a

